census record of the British colonial era. Shortly after the British conquest, a survey carried out by Charles Paton indicated the population of the province was around 100,000.[20] As with many British censuses of the colonial period, he focused as much on religion as ethnicity and identified that there were 30,000 Muslims split between three ethnic groups: a large community mainly in the north (the Rohingyas); the Kamans (a group descended from Afghan mercenaries who had served the previous dynasty); and 'a small but long established Muslim community around Moulmen'.

If, as Buddhist extremists argue, there were no Rohingyas present in 1824, all the population increase in the number of Muslims since that date must have been a product of immigration from India. We will deal with this in some detail in the next chapter but for the moment it is enough to note that the British census of 1911[21] identified the Buddhists of Arakan (that is, the Rakhine) as having a population of 210,000 (compared to 60,000 in 1824) and the Muslims as numbering 155,000. As we will see, of the latter group, the Rohingyas likely made up the majority. Since, as will be discussed in Chapter 1, some 30,000 Rohingyas returned very soon after the British conquest, this indicates that both the Rakhine and Rohingya communities grew at similar rates in the first eighty years of British rule.

However, to be clear, there was indeed migration from British-ruled India to Burma before 1937.[22] This occurred in four main areas. The British established major rice fields in the lower Irrawaddy Delta and initially imported Indian labour (as the particular form of rice production they used was not practiced in Burma). Equally, they established significant rubber plantations and again imported labour to work in these. The British also generally favoured non-Buddhists in the colonial administration (as the various Christian and Muslim ethnic groups were seen to be more loyal) and, again, workers migrated from India to fill such roles. Finally, Indian workers came to be dominant in the docks and the wider transportation sectors. None of this significantly involved the Rohingyas, who mostly carried on working as farmers and fishermen on their own land rather than taking up work in the colonial administration.

Escalating discrimination and exclusion

British rule in Burma ended in 1948 and a multi-ethnic state blessed with potential riches but facing major problems (not least a severe financial